Operations Fundamentals · Module 1

Recording script.

Running time about 13 minutes read aloud, closer to 15 once you pause and draw, in three chapters. Record each chapter as its own Loom if that's easier; the timings beside each slide are a guide, not a target. ▸ marks a stage direction: pause, look up, or draw on paper. Say it in your own words; the script is there so you never lose the thread.

Opening

1

0:41

Process is one of eight.

▸ **Camera on, slide up.** Hi, I'm Mila. I'm a fractional COO, which means my job is to know a bit about every part of a business and exactly where my limits are. This first module is the frame for everything else in the course. By the end of it you'll have all eight parts of your own business mapped, each with a name against it, and you'll have run one real decision past all eight. It's about 15 minutes, in three short chapters, and then there's a worksheet. Grab it now if you haven't already.

Chapter 1 · What operations is

2

0:08

What operations is.

Chapter 1, about five minutes. Let's start with what it actually is, because most founders have never been told.

3

0:29

What is operations?

This is the question I ask every founder I work with. **Pause** the video and answer it for yourself. ▸ **Pause.** Almost everyone says some version of the same thing: process. Systems. SOPs. Admin. Getting things written down. And that's not wrong. It's just one part. Process is one of eight. The rest of this chapter is the other seven.

4

0:38

Everything that makes the business work, behind what the customer sees.

Here's the definition we'll use for the whole course. Operations is everything that makes the business work, behind what the customer sees. The customer sees your product, your service, your marketing, the conversations they have with you. Operations is everything that has to happen behind that for the business to deliver, get paid, stay legal and keep going. When it works, nobody notices. When it doesn't, the customer feels it quickly: an invoice goes out wrong, a deadline's missed, a contract turns out to say something nobody expected.

5

0:21

You've been doing it since your first invoice.

And here's the thing: you already have operations. Even if it's just you. The day you agreed your first price, sent your first invoice or signed your first contract, you were doing operations. Nobody called it that, so nobody owns it. Which usually means it lives in your head.

6

0:45

The work

Operations has eight parts. I call them panels, and you'll see why in the next chapter. Eight is a lot to hold, so they come in four pairs. The work: process and people, how the work gets done and by whom. The money: commercial and finance, what you charge, and what comes in and goes out. The rules: legal and compliance, what you've agreed to and what you have to follow. Control: governance and risk, who decides and what could go wrong. Work, money, rules, control. Remember those four and the eight follow.

▶ **Draw it if you're on paper: four boxes, two words in each.**

7 Process

0:43

Process: how the work gets done, step by step, and the tools it runs on. Where files live, who has the passwords. People: who does the work. Hiring paperwork, contracts, getting people started, holidays and sickness, people leaving, and who does what. Commercial: what you sell, at what price, on what terms. Proposals, pricing, discounts, payment terms, customer contracts. Finance: money in and money out. Invoicing and getting paid, paying suppliers and staff, keeping records, setting tax aside. And knowing how much cash you actually have, which is not the same as profit. We'll come back to that in module 3.

8 Legal

0:52

Legal: what the business has agreed to and stands on. How the company's set up, contracts with customers, suppliers and staff, and who owns the work you create. Compliance: the rules you have to follow, and being able to show that you do. Filings and registrations, personal data, health and safety, insurance, licences if your sector needs them. Which rules apply depends on your business and where you operate; we'll cover how to find out in module 4. Governance: who decides, who's accountable, and how you check. In a small company that might be just you, but someone still has to be clear which decisions need whom. Risk: what could go wrong, how likely, how bad, and what you'd do about it.

9 Just admin.

0:41

Two things operations is not. It isn't just admin. Some of it is admin, but a missed deadline, an unclear contract or a bad payment term costs real money and real trust. And it isn't something you sort out once you're bigger. The habits you set with three people are the ones you'll have with thirty, unless you change them on purpose. Before the next chapter, think of one decision you made in the last month: a new client, a hire, a price, a supplier. Hold on to it. We'll turn it in chapter 3.

Chapter 2 · One ball

10 0:09

One ball.

Chapter 2, about four minutes. Why the eight only work as one thing, and who in your business is holding it.

11 0:36

Eight panels. One ball.

Picture a beach ball. Eight panels, sewn together. That’s operations. You can look at one panel at a time, but you can’t take one off and still have a ball. Every decision you make lands on the whole thing. A new client is a commercial decision, and it’s also a finance decision, a people decision, a legal one. You just might only be looking at one colour when you make it.

> ▸ On paper: draw a circle, cut it into eight, write a name in each.

12 0:27

Legal ops. Finance ops. Rev ops.

As companies grow, they tend to cut the ball up. Legal ops, finance ops, rev ops, people ops. Each team gets good at its panel, which is fine. The trouble is that each team only sees its colour. Finance sees the payment terms. Legal sees the contract. Nobody sees that the payment terms and the contract and the staffing plan are the same decision.

13 0:35

Split the ball and you split responsibility, accountability and knowledge.

Here’s what that costs. Split the ball, and you split three things. Responsibility: who has to do it. Accountability: who answers for it when it goes wrong. Knowledge: who actually knows how it works. Once those are spread across teams, things fall into the gaps between panels. Not because anyone’s bad at their job. Because nobody was holding the seams. I’ve seen this in companies of every size, and the fix is never another team. It’s someone who sees the whole ball.

14 You're holding the ball. Because nobody decided otherwise.

0:30

In most founder-led businesses, the founder holds the ball. Not because anyone decided that. Because nobody decided anything else. You set the prices, you signed the contracts, you hired the first people, so it all sits with you. That works for a while. It stops working when you're the only one who can answer a question about any of the eight, and you're also trying to run the business.

15 1

0:45

This is roughly how it changes. At the start, it's just you, holding every panel. Then panels get helpers: a bookkeeper, a freelancer, an assistant. They do the work, but you still make the calls. Then panels get owners: people who decide within limits you've agreed. And eventually someone holds the whole ball who isn't you. That might be a COO, an ops lead, or a fractional one. It's a common pattern, not a rule, and not every business needs stage four. The point is to know which stage each panel is at. Most founders have panels at different stages and don't know it.

16 You can hand over the work. The business keeps the responsibility.

0:33

One thing to hold on to. You can hand over the work. You can't hand over the responsibility. If your bookkeeper files late, the company's late. If a freelancer mishandles customer data, it's your business that answers for it. So handing a panel to someone is good, and you should. But you still need to know who has it, and how you'd know if it was going wrong. That's what the map in the exercise is for.

Chapter 3 · Turn the ball

17 Turn the ball.

0:07

Chapter 3, about four minutes. We'll take one real decision and turn it all the way round.

18 A big client offers a year of events.

0:27

Let me show you with an example. Kestrel is a made-up events agency, about 35 people. One of their biggest clients offers them a full year of events. From the commercial panel, it’s the best deal they’ve ever been offered. Bigger than anything they’ve done, a year of guaranteed revenue. Most founders would say yes on the call. Let’s turn the ball first.

19 Finance

0:47

Now turn it. Finance: the client pays in 90 days, but venues want deposits up front. So Kestrel funds the client’s events for three months. People: the team is already full, so this needs freelancers, which means contracts and onboarding. Process: the client wants sign-off on every event, which adds a step to everything. Legal: the contract gives the client all creative work, including Kestrel’s own templates they’ve used for years. Compliance: attendee personal data would sit on staff’s personal drives. Governance: the founder agreed it alone, on a call, and nobody else knew. Risk: this one client would be half of revenue. Same deal. Seven more things to know.

20 Say yes knowingly.

0:36

The point isn’t to say no. It might still be a great deal. The point is to say yes knowingly. Change what you can: push for better payment terms or a deposit. Carve out your templates from the IP clause. Move the data somewhere it belongs. Agree who decides on deals this size. And decide whether you can live with one client being half the business. The legal and data points here are illustrations, not legal advice. For a real contract, get it checked.

21 Process

0:49

Here are the eight questions. One per panel. You don’t need a meeting for this. For most decisions it’s five minutes with a notepad. Process: what changes in how the work gets done? People: who does it, and do they have the time and skills? Commercial: do the price and the terms work for us? Finance: when does cash go out, and when does it come in? Legal: what are we agreeing to, and who owns what? Compliance: which rules apply, and could we show we follow them? Governance: who is allowed to decide this, and who needs to know? Risk: what could go wrong, and could we live with it? They’re on your worksheet.

Close

22 1

0:37

Your turn. About 30 minutes, on the worksheet. One: map your eight parts. For each, write the main work, one name who looks after it, where it lives, and whether it’s owned, only you, or unsure. One name, not a team. If it’s you, write you. Two: name your weakest part, the one you’d least like a new investor to ask about. Three: take a decision that’s live right now and turn it through all eight questions. Be honest. Nobody’s marking the map. It’s for you.

23 Which part did you not know was yours?.

0:23

Last thing. When you’ve done the map, ask yourself one question: which part did you not know was yours? Most founders find at least one. Bring that answer to module 2, because that’s where we start getting things out of your head. Thanks for watching.